

AND THEY ALL FALL DOWN

High on original intent and lofty promises but disappointingly low on buzz, fall fashion took a chequered couture course

■ By Kimi Dangor

Unbeknownst to Janet Jackson and Justin Timberlake, their Super Bowl flashing fiasco has resulted in quite a fashion phenomenon on Indian shores. The term wardrobe malfunction has not only cropped up unceremoniously on the ramps of also-rans like Bennu Sehgal, but as witnessed at the recently concluded Wills Lifestyle India Fashion Week (WILLIFW) in Delhi, it has threatened to overshadow a week-long trend-table of style shenanigans.

And while the skin-tillating flash of Belgian model Debbie's assets at Rajesh Pratap's show on day three undeniably got the event maximum air-time, fashion's flirtation with fall-winter might have nearly slipped by unnoticed if it weren't for the spills and slips between the ramp and the green room. Bipasha Basu stumbled in a Gauri and Nainika Mardi Gras float-esque gown, Bhavna Sharma tripped in a Pratap ghaghra and Priya Reddy took a fall in harem pants courtesy Charu Parashar. And though the slipping and sliding—thanks to the season's voluminous floor-length frock fetish combined with faulty footwear and shiny vinyl catwalks—kept the electronic media on their toes, trend-spotters were treated to a mixed bag melee, swerving dangerously between style central and been-there-worn-that déjà vu. With the exception of Basu and Katrina Kaif (who are currently in the *Race* for box office glory), show-stoppers were relegated to Bollywood B-graders, cricketing heroes and a smattering of wannabes.

Despite the aplomb of winter's full-

skirted capacious lines, this week was high on volume, huge sleeves, big collars and lofty promises but disappointingly low on delivery. While old-timers showcased more drama than design amidst qawalli singers, dramatic dancers and war-mongering geishas, fortunately, originality, though at a premium, stood its ground on the glittery runway. New names with confident lines, strong style statements and sharp minds made their presence felt at Pragati Maidan, bringing with them a refreshing whiff of ingenuity and creative chutzpah to the jaded fashion jamboree.

Delhi boy Varun Sardana picked up the threads from last season's brilliant debut collection and presented his quirky collection Line A Quaint Little Town where stylish cowls, drapes, gathers and pleats created an interesting origami silhouette. Dropped shoulders, wide collars and cowed breeches met cardigans, knee-length skirts and a smattering of sequins. A clever play on androgyny saw Sardana dress his men in elfin 'girlfriend chic' with ruffled shirts and ruched capris. Hot on his creative heels was Pratap's former assistant Rahul Reddy, who took his mentor's clean cut lines and gave them a playful twist with detailed surface texturing. Flowers, butterflies, bees and honeycomb motifs met crisp dresses, asymmetric textured skirts and quilted shrugs.

Adding to the au courant crowd were Amit GT, Nitin Bal Chauhan and Gayatri Khanna. While Amit's line of hour glass and duchesse dresses met box pleats, flounced underskirts and faux fur detailing, Chauhan, a Lakme Fashion Week find, mixed folk with



Rahul Reddy

Clean lines met innovative and detailed surface texturing